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2. Self-Discovery

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2. Self-Discovery

Jack and Ann met at a college football game and started dating soon after their initial meeting. In walking Ann to class and in taking her to parties and games, Jack discovered some things about this woman. He quickly learned that she was a very neat person. Her clothes fit perfectly and were never wrinkled. Her papers were always carefully written.

Her dorm room was always straightened and her closet in order, despite the fact that her roommate, Stephanie, didn't care much about neatness. Stephanie was inclined to let her bed go unmade and her clothes lie in a heap. But she did not remain messy for long. Ann kept after her about her responsibilities. Sometimes Stephanie complained to Jack that Ann was too fussy. But Jack had to admire Ann's stand. After all, how could he argue with someone who took the lead in keeping things neat, even to the point of doing the job herself when Stephanie failed?

Jack also had great respect for Ann's academic achievements, and even greater respect for the way she got her good grades. Ann was a serious student. Nothing came ahead of the books. He often wished he had just half her drive. He was too easily satisfied with just getting by. But things began to change after they became better acquainted. He felt she inspired him.

"Let's unwind over a pizza," he would say after classes.

"Let's work on your English literature paper first," she'd reply.

Jack never paid too much attention to his appearance until Ann opened his eyes to the holes in his shirts or his need for a haircut. He began consulting her on how to dress whenever they went out.

Also, Ann got him back into church. He had become lax, but now always went with her—and they arrived on time.

What more could anyone ask? When a guy improves his appearance, raises his grades, becomes more punctual, and gets interested in church, isn't it all to the good? Jack was quite intrigued that a girl had done so much for him, and only slightly annoyed that without her he had been unable to see himself as he really was.

Their courtship was casual, quite uneventful. They talked everything over and settled all issues. Once in a while, however, Jack had to admit to himself that he found relief in getting back to his room where he could relax, sprawl out, and pick things up only when he felt like it. Even so, he knew her way was better.

Shortly after graduation they were married. The ceremony went off flawlessly. Ann's mother had thought of every detail; the music, the procession, the vows, the reception—all ticked off with clocklike precision.

Having majored in business administration, Jack was soon hired by a large company as a management trainee. Ann got a job teaching fourth grade. Together their paychecks allowed them to rent a nice apartment and have money left over for many extras.

One night, at Jack's suggestion, they went out to look at cars. He wanted to see the new models; she thought they ought to limit themselves to a used car. He had long dreamed of someday owning a beautiful, powerful new car, and only reluctantly did he put aside the idea. Ann reminded him that they needed to save their money to buy a house, and he could see that she was right.

Jack had a habit of coming home from work, settling down on the couch, and kicking off his shoes. Quietly, Ann would pick up the shoes and put them in the closet. After a short nap Jack would jump up and feel for his shoes.

"Where are my shoes?" he would call, loudly enough for Ann to hear him in the next room.

Ann never shouted. She would come to the living room and say very evenly, "In the closet, dear."

Jack also routinely peeled off his suit coat and draped it over a chair. When he wanted it again—no coat.

"Where's my coat?" he would shout impatiently.

And again, Ann would come to the room and answer, "In the closet."

She was quiet, steady, dependable. How could you quarrel with her way of life? Because she was the way she was, Jack always bit off the harsh words on the tip of his tongue. It was better that way.

They always ate dinner at 6 o'clock sharp. At times Jack would take a nap before and once in a while he would sleep right up to the dinner time. Invariably, Ann would be seated. He would mumble an apology for being late, and grace would sound a little forced.

By the second year of their marriage they had saved enough money to make a down payment on a house. They decided to have a home built, but it was difficult to decide on a neighborhood and even more difficult to agree on the floorplan. They came closer to an argument over those decisions than over anything in the past.

Once the house was built, they needed new furnishings. Jack wanted to buy what they wanted on credit; Ann convinced him that this wasn't wise. So they moved in the few pieces of furniture they owned. The living room looked empty to Jack, and he wondered how long it would take to make this house look like a home.

He wanted to have the yard sodded, but Ann called his notion extravagant. "You can seed it yourself after work," she said.

About this time a coolness began to develop between them. The usual hug-and-kiss greeting no longer provided the pleasure it once had. They kept up the ritual, but it became a chore. Because conversation at times threatened to border on controversy, long silences developed.

They were both glad to spend their evenings reading, watching television, attending church functions, or visiting friends—anything to keep from talking to each other. Each was afraid to ask the other, "What's wrong?"

Neither could put a finger on any real issue between them. Yet something seemed to separate them. They ought to talk more, they decided, since each knew that communication was important to a successful marriage. So they tried talking more. In one of their long talks they settled once and for all that there was no unresolved issue between them. They kissed, declared their love for each other, and agreed sincerely that they saw eye to eye. Yet each knew something was still wrong between them.

Jack and Ann felt frustrated. They were an educated, dedicated, ambitious couple who shared common goals, were active together in church, and were loyal to each other. What was this quiet, mysterious, sinister force that threatened their marriage?

You cannot wish trouble away. You must get at it by uncovering the cause and removing it.

When they came for counseling, Ann said, “Dr. Brandt, we prefer to be together as we talk to you.”

“That’s right,” agreed her husband. “You see, we do everything together. We have nothing to hide from each other.”

That first session was a puzzling one. I could come up with no clue to their trouble. There were no issues, no unresolved problems. Only one suggestion occurred to me.

“Will you watch for any differences of opinion that may arise this week and pay attention to your reactions?” I asked. “And will you try to review your life together to see if there can possibly be any unresolved problems?”

Ann broke in, “I’m sure there are none. We love each other and solve any problem as soon as it comes up.”

“That’s true,” said Jack, right behind her. “Are you suggesting that we aren’t honest and open with each other?” Turning to his wife he said tenderly, “You are open with me, aren’t you, Ann?”

Her answer was to nestle in his outstretched arms. They looked at me as if I were an enemy seeking to drive them apart.

Surprisingly, they were back the next week. Neither had seen any sense in what I had suggested, and neither had anything to share. Yet that nagging coolness remained, and they had to admit that something *was* wrong, something they either could not or would not see. Gently but firmly I urged them to try again to discover it.

“If there is an ache in your body, something is wrong,” I reminded them. “No matter how reluctant you are to admit it, you must find and correct the trouble to get rid of the ache. Coolness between people is like an ache. Something is wrong. This may be a frightening idea, and you may prefer that it did not exist; but you cannot wish trouble away. You must get at it by uncovering the cause and removing it.”

The next week they returned. Ann asked to see me alone. She entered my office, closed the door, slumped into a chair, buried her face in her hands, and began to cry uncontrollably.

What had happened? She had made a discovery, and not a pleasant one. The past week had been rainy. Their lawn still wasn't in, so naturally mud had been tracked into the house. Tuesday was an especially trying day in her classroom, and she knew she had to go to a church meeting that night. She was tired, worn out physically, and fed up with the mud that seemed to be everywhere. As she stood at the kitchen sink peeling potatoes for dinner, she heard a car pull up in the rutted driveway. That would be Jack. The door opened and slammed.

"Take off your shoes on the landing!" she shouted, too tired to go to the stairs as she usually did. She heard one shoe fall, then the other. Jack came into the kitchen; absentmindedly she asked, "Did you take your shoes off?"

"Yes, I took my shoes off!" he yelled.

Ann broke into tears. "You don't need to shout at me."

"You don't need to shout at me either," he snapped. He was furious.

I learned from Jack later that he had wavered between two impulses. One was to take her in his arms; the other was to run. He chose to run. Into the bathroom he went, slamming the door behind him. Once there, he felt ashamed and confused. Not knowing what to do, he slipped into the living room and hid behind the evening paper.

Ann called Jack for dinner at 6 p.m. as usual. He went silently to his chair. They said a prayer together but with considerable strain. Jack looked up to see Ann's eyes were red and swollen. She looked so pathetic, but he was frozen in his chair. There was nothing he could think of to say. Ann had nothing to say. So they didn't talk about the incident. And they hadn't brought it up since, not until Ann mentioned it in her interview with me alone.

Later Jack came into the office for a private talk. I told him that Ann had shared with me the shouting episode. He was upset.

"She told you about *that*?" He had assumed she would keep such things to herself. He certainly would have. Then he assured me that their spat was only an isolated incident. Why make a mountain out of a molehill?

That was a good question. I turned it back to him. "You're right, why make a mountain out of a molehill?"

“What do you mean?” he replied.

“For an isolated incident, it seems to me that both of you are carrying this rather far.”

Jack became thoughtful. Perhaps I was right, he said ruefully. This little incident had created a thick wall between them.

A week of silence followed during which neither exerted any effort to make up. At the next visit they again met with me individually. Ann had little to say except to remark that Jack seemed very distant. The whole situation was muddled to her. She just couldn't think.

Jack was more talkative. He had done some thinking, and he didn't like what he was coming up with. During the week his mind had wandered back to their courtship days. Yes, he had admired Ann's neatness. He had also entertained a thought or two in those days that maybe she was a bit too fussy. But he had never allowed so unkind a thought to linger. Now, by contrast, he noticed more frequently her fussiness, and he found himself dwelling on the thought and being annoyed by it.

He remembered how Ann constantly prodded her college roommate to be neat. *Now, he was thinking, she's keeping after me in the same way.* He realized that he resented the push.

Oh sure, Ann had changed his whole life for the better. But when she hadn't pushed him into a change, she had pulled him.

I asked Jack if he had shared his thoughts with his wife.

“Are you kidding?” He was amazed at my question.

“Why don't you?”

“No,” he smiled, but not happily. “I don't think that's a good idea.”

Jack apparently had forgotten that he had told me during our first session that he and Ann talked everything over and he had nothing to hide from her. No doubt they both believed what they were saying.

It is indeed true that a person can deceive himself. According to the Bible, “The human heart is the most deceitful of all things, and desperately wicked. Who really knows how bad it is? I the LORD search the heart and test the mind, to give every

man according to his ways, according to the fruit of his deeds” (Jeremiah 17:9–10).

Evidently, when Jack and Ann said they shared everything, they meant sharing what they thought would not disturb the other.

I asked Jack, “How would Ann take it if you shared your thoughts with her?”

He didn’t know and said he would not even consider talking to her as he had talked to me. In fact, he felt terribly guilty for having told me such things. His wife was a wonderful woman. He owed a lot to her; she had inspired him to work hard, to set wise goals for his life, to take his responsibility as a Christian seriously. If it hadn’t been for her, he might have drifted far away from the Lord. But after he said all that, the resentments of her fastidiousness, her bossiness, her pushing were still there.

Toward the end of our session, I called attention to the apostle Paul’s goals as outlined in Philippians 3. Paul realized that he was not perfect. Still he was open to learning. This willingness to know and to be known was what he called perfection. He added that for anyone who would be perfect, God would reveal any reluctance to know or to be known. Look at his exact words:

I don’t mean to say that I have already achieved these things or that I have already reached perfection. But I press on to possess that perfection for which Christ Jesus first possessed me. No, dear brothers and sisters, I have not achieved it, but I focus on this one thing: Forgetting the past and looking forward to what lies ahead, I press on to reach the end of the race and receive the heavenly prize for which God, through Christ Jesus, is calling us. Let all who are spiritually mature agree on these things. If you disagree on some point, I believe God will make it plain to you. —Philippians 3:12–15

“Maturity,” I told Jack, “is not having arrived, but the will to see new light. Personal growth and development is based squarely on an honest look at yourself with the intent to correct any failings you may discover.”

An Honest Look

So, how *do* you discover yourself? Quite often through relationships. Through their marriage relationship, Ann and Jack learned some things about themselves. Parents get to know their true selves through experiences with their children. Some people get glimpses of themselves through working for or alongside others. The intense

competition of sports will mirror the character of an athlete. Your relationships with people and your responses to the events of life will bring into focus both your personal strengths and your weaknesses. Are you willing to honestly take a look at how you are interacting with and responding to others?

Through the eyes of your family, friends, and coworkers you can learn a great deal about yourself.

For the purpose of perfecting his people God has also ordained pastors, evangelists, and teachers (see Ephesians 4:11–12). One who clearly exhibits the marks of his God-given call cannot only help you see yourself, but help you grow into maturity as you deal with the truth you discover.

Are you willing to honestly take a look at how you are interacting with and responding to others?

However, if your self-discovery is to be meaningful, it must be measured against a standard. I truly believe that for Christians, regardless of the *means* to self-discovery, the Bible provides our *standard* for living. For example, if you discover bitterness in your heart toward others, you must measure yourself against the biblical standard for love found in 1 Thessalonians 3:12: “May the Lord make your love for one another and for all people grow and overflow.” God’s Word is “alive and powerful. It is sharper than the sharpest two-edged sword, cutting between soul and spirit, between joint and marrow. It exposes our innermost thoughts and desires” (Hebrews 4:12). It is “inspired by God and is useful to teach us what is true and to make us realize what is wrong in our lives. It corrects us when we are wrong and teaches us to do what is right” (2 Timothy 3:16). It “shows us how sinful we are” (Romans 3:20). King David said, “Your word is a lamp to guide my feet and a light for my path” (Psalm 119:105).

You may be a Christian. That is, you have invited Jesus to come into your life as your Savior. He has forgiven your sins and you have experienced his peace. Now, however, he seems very distant. Perhaps a root of bitterness troubles you. Perhaps you are nursing hatred, resentment, malice, or anger toward someone who has misused you. There is something between you and God, and only biblical advice can clear away the fog that makes him seem far away. The prophet Isaiah said, “Let the wicked change their ways and banish the very thought of doing wrong. Let them turn to the Lord that he may have mercy on them. Yes, turn to our God, for he will forgive generously” (Isaiah 55:7).

The psalmist wanted to know himself, and he understood that ultimately it would take God to help him do it:

Search me, O God, and know my heart; test me and know my anxious thoughts. Point out anything in me that offends you, and lead me along the path of everlasting life. —Psalm 139:23-24

It is one thing for a person to say in all sincerity that he wants to know himself, but the experience of doing so is quite another. A revealing glimpse of yourself is seldom an easy one. Self-discovery can be painful. Nevertheless, do not shrink from it. Jesus said, “Light has come into the world, but people love darkness instead of light.” Our human tendency is to prefer not to come to the light because the light exposes our sin.

For Jack and Ann, discovering their true natures was indeed a painful process. They considered themselves sincere Christians—and they were. They believed they were devoted to one another and dedicated to a like-minded partnership—and they were. To them, their sincerity meant that if their objectives were askew, God would have revealed this to them. God was at work in their lives, but it did not seem like it—not with this thick wall of silence between them, or Ann’s tears, or Jack’s temper.

What caused the buildup of their “crisis”? To get the answer, each had to want to know the truth about themselves.

As time went on, Jack gradually discovered that though he had given in to Ann consistently, there were deep-seated reservations in his heart and vague irritation over some of his decisions to go along with her logical arguments. He accepted her neatness and thrift and the pace she set for him in church activity. He accepted intellectually, that is—but not wholeheartedly. He was like the little boy who, when told by his father to sit down in the car, sat down but said that inside he was still standing up.

Jack’s experiences with Ann brought him to discover himself. Conditions in his job confirmed his discovery. He realized he was doing the same thing there—conceding to well-reasoned propositions outwardly, but not inwardly. As the apostle Paul put it, “Work *willingly* at whatever you do, as though you were working for the Lord rather than for people” (Colossians 3:23, emphasis added).

Jack had strong opinions and did not readily accept the views of others. With friends he could drift in and out of associations, which he did frequently in an effort to be comfortable. But when he married, he could not trade his wife for another when she annoyed him. The result was a growing sense of dissatisfaction. Since he could not escape from this discomfort, he tried to isolate himself from it by building a wall between himself and Ann.

On that rainy day his dissatisfaction suddenly flared, and he himself was surprised by it. Fortunately, that shouting episode brought his problem into focus. He saw that he was not admitting to himself that he was making concessions he did not want to make, even though he was agreeing verbally to what was reasonable, logical, and desirable. He discovered his selfish nature.

But what was he to do with this discovery? He could deny or ignore it and be like the man who looked at himself in the three-way mirror while buying a suit and was horrified by his double chin and bulging waist. The man's response from then on was to stay away from three-way mirrors. Jack could also admit the truth of his discovery, but confession would not mean correction.

Ann found out some things about herself too. She had had her own way most of the time, thanks to her ingenuity and power of persuasion. It was true that her standards were fine ones. But Ann was also a very determined woman. This trait showed itself when she insisted on a neat room in college, even if she had to do her roommate's share of the work. It was apparent in the way she kept after Jack to hang up his coat and put away his shoes. Ann thought of herself as determined, but Stephanie and Jack perceived her to be stubborn.

When Ann failed to win people over by logic, she broke into tears or lapsed into silence until her opponent gave in. She just couldn't or wouldn't back down.

Ann came to see this herself. What was she to do with this discovery? Now knowing her strengths and weaknesses, was she to manipulate them to further serve her own selfish ends? Or should she admit her stubborn nature with a view to changing? If she chose to defend her emotional ups and downs, she now knew she needed to use the Bible as the standard by which to determine whether her defense was valid. If, under the guidance of the Holy Spirit, she found she did not measure up to that standard, she had the grace of God available to change her.

Moving Forward

Self-discovery is painful because it uncovers streaks in your makeup that you wish were not there—but which cannot be wished away. It confirms what John wrote almost 2,000 years ago: “If we claim we have no sin, we are only fooling ourselves and not living in the truth” (1 John 1:8).

The objective is not mere introspection, but an inward look for the purpose of moving on to higher ground. What causes me to be the way I am? I want to know because I don’t want to live like this any longer. Other people have come to this conclusion about me a long time ago; it is about time I catch up with them.

Marriage, parenthood, a social situation, or your job may be the means to discovering your true self. But do not look for the root of your problem in your marriage partner or children or uncooperative neighbor or boss; rather look for it in yourself. That which reveals a problem is not the problem itself. To treat the symptom is not to cure the disease.

Self-discovery is painful because it uncovers streaks in your makeup that you wish were not there—but which cannot be wished away.

For a life of peace, you must discover your true self. Then, to know what you have found, you must measure it by God’s standard. You will find yourself short—everyone does. “For everyone has sinned; we all fall short of God’s glorious standard” (Romans 3:23). This is the reason you need the help which only Jesus Christ can give you. He alone can make you what you ought to be. Proverbs 28:13 encourages us with these words: “People who conceal their sins will not prosper, but if they confess and turn from them, they will receive mercy.”

For Jack and Ann to change, they had to acknowledge their faults to themselves and one another, set aside their excuses, and truly seek forgiveness, cleansing, and spiritual strength on a daily basis. For Jack, he needed to admit that he only pretended agreement, deceived people, and hid an angry spirit. For Ann, she needed to admit her selfishness, stubbornness, and resentment.

Jack and Ann also had to move from verbal agreements to mental and spiritual assent. As the Bible declares, “I appeal to you, brothers and sisters, in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, that all of you agree with one another in what you say and that there be no divisions among you, but that you be perfectly united in mind and thought” (1 Corinthians 1:10, NIV). They needed to invite God into the process of helping them to overcome their divisions.

And so do you, to solve your problem. You need the help which only Jesus Christ can give you. He alone can make you what you want and ought to be.

Ask yourself these questions:

- What am I really like?
- What does a pat on the back do for me?
- In what ways am I offended by a rebuke?
- How do I respond when I am crossed? mistreated? misunderstood?
- In what ways do I need to allow God to change me?

Reflection Questions

1. In what areas of your life are currently experiencing frustration and unhappiness?
2. When do you experience the most irritation?
3. Honestly, are you willing to allow the Bible to be your standard for life? What difference does the answer to this question make?
4. If you are going to experience true peace, what attitudes do you need to change?
5. Take a few moments to answer the five bulleted questions included at the end of this chapter.

Take One Action Step

Choose one way in which you can begin the process of self-discovery. Conscientiously pursue that one step and note what you learn.